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California advances 2 bills that could impact your grocery shopping

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Two bills in the California Legislature that could impact your trip to the grocery store have cleared the Assembly ahead of the chamber's Friday deadline, leaving only the state Senate before the bills arrive on Gov. Gavin Newsom's desk for a signature.

The first, Assembly Bill 418, would ban the manufacture, sale and distribution of food products containing five specific chemicals that have been linked to cancer and other health risks. The popular candy product Skittles contains one of those chemicals — titanium dioxide — meaning that, if the bill is passed into law, the brand must either change its recipe or halt the sale of the product in California altogether.

"Californians shouldn't have to worry that the food they buy in their neighborhood grocery store might be full of dangerous additives or toxic chemicals," Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, the bill's author, said in a press release announcing the legislation. "This bill will correct for a concerning lack of federal oversight and help protect our kids, public health, and the safety of our food supply."

Gabriel has said he believes Skittles' parent company Mars Inc. would opt to change recipes before it abandons the California market. Mars Inc. publicly opposes the legislation and has not commented on what it would do if Newsom signs it into law.

The second bill, Assembly Bill 1347, would require businesses with annual revenues of more than $25 million to offer customers options when it comes to getting a receipt, meaning that cashiers would no longer be able to give customers a traditional paper receipt without first asking if that's their preference. Instead, customers would be able to choose an emailed receipt or no receipt at all.

Originally, the bill was written so it applied to all businesses in California, but it was amended to businesses with annual revenues of more than $25 million (think Walmart, Target and Walgreens instead of your local corner store) to align with the state's consumer privacy law, which only applies to businesses that make more than $25 million per year. The bill also stipulates that all businesses issuing paper receipts must ensure that the receipts do not contain chemicals that can disrupt the body's endocrine system — if the bill becomes law, any business that flaunts that requirement will be subject to daily fines, up to $300 per year, after two warnings.

"When we get coffee to-go or a pack of gum, most of us don't want or need a physical receipt. It's time we provide customers with the option to get no receipt or a digital receipt. It doesn't make sense to kill so many trees and produce billions pounds of carbon emissions," Assemblymember Phil Ting, the bill's author, said in a press release announcing the bill. "AB 1347 gives customers a choice and still provides for customers to request a paper receipt when they need it."

Friday is the last day for lawmakers to pass bills in the house in which they originated, meaning any bills introduced in the Assembly that are not on their way to the Senate by the end of the day — and vice versa — are considered dead for all intents and purposes. The two bills could still be amended or killed in the state Senate before they head to Newsom's desk.

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